

Mandarin, Step by Step, Character by Character

A composition-driven introduction to standard Mandarin

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Starter edition — seven short lessons in one cumulative chapter.

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How to use this starter edition

Begin with no assumed Chinese. Each section takes one small expression, teaches only the characters and sounds needed for it, shows what those characters are built from, and ends with a short retrieval prompt. There is no character list to memorise first.

Two things about Mandarin will be new to a reader coming from a European language, and this book meets both in its first chapter rather than deferring them. The first is that Chinese is written in *characters*, not letters: each one is an evenly sized block built from smaller recurring components, and words are one or more of those blocks. The second is that *pitch is part of the word*. Said on a high flat note, a falling note, or a low dipping one, the same syllable is three different words. That is not emphasis; it is as much a part of the word as a consonant.

This book is also honest about one thing it cannot do. A related language would let a new word be attached to English words the reader already owns through a shared ancestor — Spanish *gracias* to *grace* and *gratitude*. Chinese and English share no ancestor, so there are no cousins to show, and inventing some would be worse than having none. What replaces them here is the composition of the characters themselves: 好 is 女, woman, beside 子, child. That is a real and visible structure, and it does help — but it anchors a new word to knowledge you are acquiring in the same breath rather than to knowledge you already had, so it is a weaker hook than a shared ancestor would give. Where a component gloss is a traditional memory picture rather than settled history, this book says so.

Romanization (pinyin) stays beside the characters in this starter edition and will fade gradually. The variety taught is standard Mandarin in simplified characters; traditional characters are a labelled future edition, not a silent substitute.

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Chapter 1

Nǐ Hǎo — Hello, Character by Character

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 👁️ eyes (2) 🖐️ Hands-free start: all 7 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can greet someone in Mandarin and answer when greeted, reading both characters unaided and saying the greeting with the tone a speaker actually uses rather than the one the dictionary prints.

A two-line meeting in which both voices say the same word — read from the characters alone, with the first third tone raised by sandhi.

1.1 mā má mǎ mà — one syllable, four words

Nothing to recall yet. Before the first Chinese word arrives, one thing your voice is about to be asked to do that English never asks of it.

The sounds and tones in this word

In English, pitch carries mood. *Really.* and *Really?* are the same word, said two ways.

In Mandarin, **pitch is part of the word**, exactly the way a consonant is. Take the syllable *ma* and give it four different pitches and you get four unrelated words:

- **mā** — held high and flat, one steady note. *Mother.*
- **má** — rising, like the pitch on a surprised English “huh?”. *Hemp.*

- **mǎ** — dipping low, a little creaky. *Horse*.
- **mà** — falling sharply, like a clipped “No!”. *To scold*.

There is a fifth, the **neutral** tone: short, light, no mark written at all. The accent over the vowel is how the romanization writes the tone: a flat bar in **mā**, a rising stroke in **má**, a hook in **mǎ**, a falling stroke in **mà**. The Chinese characters themselves record no tone anywhere, so the accent is a teaching aid, not part of the writing.

Say all four in order now, slowly: **mā, má, mǎ, mà**. [REPEAT x2]

Your turn

- *Say it:* **mā** high and flat, then **mà** falling — hear how far apart they are
- *Answer:* if you change the pitch of a Mandarin syllable, what changes?

Before you move on

Which accent tells you to dip low? (The hook, as in **mǎ**.) Does changing a Mandarin tone change how you feel about a word, or which word it is? (Which word it is.)

Source: the tone inventory this track keeps

1.2 你 — “you”, and the first character

Say the four tones on *ma* once, in order. Hold the third one — low and dipping. The first Chinese word carries exactly that pitch.

The sounds and tones in this word

nǐ. The *n* is the English *n*; the *i* is the *ee* of “see”. The hook over it is the **third tone**: start low, stay low, let it creak. [REPEAT x2]

Script — 你, and the person hiding on its left

Chinese is not written with letters. It is written with **characters**, each an evenly sized square block, and each block built from smaller recurring pieces

called **components**.

你 has two of them, left and right:

亻 + 尔 → 你

亻 is the “person” component. On its own the character for a person is 人 — two legs walking. Push it to the left edge of a block and it is squashed upright into 亻 : one short slant over one vertical. Same piece, standing sideways to make room.

尔 on the right is there for its *sound*, not its meaning. Chinese builds most of its characters this way — one component pointing at the meaning, another at the pronunciation.

Stroke order is a real, taught system here: top before bottom, left before right. So 亻 first, then 尔.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

你 *nǐ* — **you**, addressing one person.

Here this book has to be honest with you. A related language lets a new word be anchored to English words you already own through a shared ancestor — Spanish *gracias* to *grace* and *gratitude*, all from Latin *gratia*. **Chinese shares no ancestor with English.** There is no cousin web for *nǐ*, and inventing one would be worse than having none.

What replaces it is what you just read: the character is itself decomposable, and its pieces mean things. 你 carries a person on its left because it is about a person. That is the hook — not history you share with English, but structure you can see.

Your turn

- *Say it*: **nǐ** — low and dipping, not flat
- *Read it*: 你 — name its left piece, then its right piece

Before you move on

Which component of 你 tells you the word is about a person? (亻 .)

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

1.3 好 — “good”, and what replaces etymology here

Say the word for “you” without looking. Which of its two components is the person? Now hold that low, dipping pitch — the next word wants the same one.

The sounds and tones in this word

hǎo. The *h* is a little rougher than English *h*, scraped at the back of the mouth. The *ao* is one gliding vowel, the *ow* of “how”. The hook accent is the same third tone you already met: low, dipping, creaky. [REPEAT x2]

Script — 好, a woman beside a child

Two components again, side by side:

女 + 子 → 好

女 on the left is the character for “woman”: a crossing stroke, a curved leg, a horizontal through the middle. 子 on the right is “child”: a hooked top, a hooked vertical, a horizontal arm. Left before right, as always.

Notice what just happened. 女 and 子 are not letters spelling out the sound *hǎo* — neither is pronounced anything like it. They are whole characters with their own meanings, reused as building blocks.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

好 *hǎo* — **good**, and also **well**.

A woman beside a child, and the character means “good”. That picture is the hook — and it stands in for the cousin web that a related language would supply, because **Chinese and English share no ancestor** and there is no honest chain from *hǎo* to any English word. Two cautions, because a memory aid that pretends to be history rots:

- “Woman + child = good” is the **traditional gloss**. It is genuinely useful for remembering the shape, but palaeographers do not all accept it as the historical origin; some read 子 as a phonetic element instead. A picture that helps, not a proven derivation.

- Component glosses are hooks, not translations. 好 does not “mean” woman-child. It means good.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **hǎo** — low and dipping, the *ow* of “how”
- *Read it:* 好 — name its left component, then its right one
- *Answer:* why does this track use component pictures instead of English cousins?

Before you move on

What does 好 mean? (Good, or well.) Is its woman-and-child picture a proven etymology? (No — a traditional and useful gloss, disputed as history.)

Source: Unicode Han database, character 好

1.4 你好 — the greeting, assembled from two things you already have

Two characters, both already yours. Say the one that means “you”. Say the one that means “good”. Now put them in that order and you have said hello — but say it slowly for one more moment, because the tones are about to do something.

The exchange

你好 *nǐ hǎo!* Hello.

你好 *nǐ hǎo!* Hello.

The greeting and its answer are the same word. Say it to one person you have just met, at any hour of the day.

Grammar Lens — a word can be more than one character

English counts a word in **letters**. Chinese does not have letters, so the tempting guess is that it counts a word in **characters** — one character, one word. That guess is wrong, and correcting it early saves

a great deal of confusion.

A character writes one **syllable** and usually one **meaningful piece**.

A **word** is one or more of those pieces:

- 你 — one character, one word: *you*
- 好 — one character, one word: *good*
- 你好 — two characters, still **one word**: *hello*

Nobody hearing 你好 parses it as “you good”, any more than an English speaker hears “good” and “bye” inside *goodbye*. The pieces are visible, which makes the word easy to remember; the whole is what it means.

Why it's said this way

你好 is safe, neutral, and understood everywhere — which is exactly why a course teaches it first. But it is worth knowing that it is used less freely than English “hello”. Between people who already know each other, a Mandarin speaker is more likely to open with a small situational remark than with 你好 at all. Reserve it for meeting someone, and you will sound right.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **nǐ hǎo** — greeting someone you have just met
- *Say it:* **nǐ hǎo** — answering that same greeting
- *Answer:* how many characters is this word, and how many words is it?

Before you move on

Which character comes first, and what does it mean on its own?

(你, “you”.) Is 你好 one word or two? (One.)

Source: Unicode Han database, characters 你 and 好

1.5 ní hǎo — why the greeting is not said the way it is written

Say the greeting once, slowly, giving both syllables the low dipping third tone you were taught. It should feel awkward in the mouth. That awkwardness is the whole lesson.

Grammar Lens — one rule, and it is not optional

When two third tones come one after the other, the first is spoken as a second (rising) tone.

So the greeting, written **nǐ hǎo**, is actually said **ní hǎo** — the first syllable climbs instead of dipping. [REPEAT x2]

Nothing about this shows in the writing. Dictionaries print **nǐ hǎo**, because that is the citation tone each word carries on its own, and the characters 你好 never change at all. A learner who trusts only what is written will say the commonest greeting in the language wrong every time.

Why does it happen? Two dipping tones in a row would need the voice to sink, climb, sink and climb again inside a fifth of a second. Speakers do not do that; the first one gives way. This is a real rule of the sound system, not a sloppy shortcut, and every native speaker applies it without thinking.

Compare it to what English does with “*the*”: written one way, said *thuh* before a consonant and *thee* before a vowel, and no English speaker thinks of that as two words. The difference is that here the change lands on **pitch** — the same property that distinguishes one word from another.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **ní hǎo** — first syllable rising, second dipping
- *Say it:* it again, at speaking speed, without the pause between them
- *Answer:* which spelling changes when the rule applies — pinyin, characters, or neither?

Before you move on

Two third tones meet. What happens to the first? (It rises.) What happens to the characters? (Nothing.)

Source: Chinese Text Project, on tone in Mandarin

1.6 好 again — proof, on a character you own, that tone is the word

Name the character built from a woman and a child, and say what it means. Hold its tone: low and dipping.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

The very same character, 好, has a second reading — and the only thing that separates the two is the tone:

- 好 *hǎo*, dipping third tone — **good**
- 好 *hào*, sharply falling fourth tone — **to be fond of, to like**

Same strokes. Same components. Same shape on the page. Two words. This is the cleanest proof available of what the first lesson claimed. Tone is not decoration on a word; it is *inside* the word, doing the job a consonant does in English. Change *hǎo* to *hào* and you have not said “good” with feeling — you have said a different word, the way *bat* and *pat* are different words.

The two readings are related in meaning, and the relation is a good hook: what is **good** is what one is **fond of**. That is a link inside Chinese, between two readings of one character. It is not a link to English. There is none.

You are not asked to produce **hào** yet. Recognising it is the point: when a familiar character turns up wearing an unfamiliar tone, the tone is telling you this is a different word.

Your turn

- *Answer:* **hǎo** or **hào** — which one means “good”?
- *Answer:* what changed between them, and what stayed the same?

- *Answer:* which two components is this character built from?

Before you move on

One character carried two words today. What told them apart?
(Only the tone.)

Source: Unicode Han database, character 好

1.7 Practice — greet someone, and be greeted back

Retrieve the two words separately first: the one meaning “you”, then the one meaning “good”. Do not run them together yet.

The exchange

A: 你好 *nǐ hǎo!* B: 你好 *nǐ hǎo!*

Two lines, one word, both voices. Every piece is already yours: the characters from their own lessons, the meaning from the greeting lesson, the rising first syllable from the sandhi rule. Nothing new is hiding here.

Say A’s line, pause, then answer as B. [REPEAT x2]

What you’ve built this chapter

Four things, and only one of them is vocabulary:

- 你 is 亻 plus 尔; 好 is 女 beside 子. Characters are built from parts.
- Those parts are the memory hook this track uses, because Chinese and English share no ancestor and therefore no cousin web.
- 你好 is two characters and one word. Characters are not letters.
- Pitch is part of the word, and a neighbouring word can change it without changing a stroke.

Your turn

- *Say it:* greet someone you have just met

- *Say it:* answer that greeting
- *Read it:* 你好 aloud from the characters alone, with no pinyin

Before you move on

Run both lines once more. If the first syllable dips instead of rising, go back to the sandhi lesson only — not to the whole chapter.

Source: Unicode Han database, characters 你 and 好

Chapter 2

Reading the Greeting — One Piece at a Time

Modes: ✓ pen (7) ⇌ Hands-free start: none of the 7 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can write each component the greeting's two characters are built from, and then assemble both characters from those pieces rather than recalling them as whole shapes.

The second assembly, built from two components the reader wrote individually a moment earlier — and a caution that the memorable story about why it means what it means is a story, not a source.

2.1 人 — two strokes, and a person walking

You have heard Mandarin pitch. Now you meet the writing, and this book will hand it to you **one piece at a time** — never a character you have not been shown the parts of first.

This is the whole first piece:

人

Two strokes. That is the entire character.

Script — the shape

人 *rén* means **person**.

Look at it before you read another word about it. A stroke leaning down-left, a stroke leaning down-right, meeting at the top. **It is a figure standing on two legs, seen from the side.** You are not being asked to take that on faith — the oldest surviving forms of this character, scratched into ox bone three thousand years ago, are recognisably a standing person, and the two legs are the part that lasted.

Write it in this order, and the order is not a suggestion:

1. the **left** stroke, from the top down to the lower left — a falling sweep
2. the **right** stroke, starting near the top of the first and pressing down to the lower right

Left before right. Almost every character you meet will obey it, and it is worth meeting here — on a character with two strokes — rather than later on one with fifteen.

The pitch is **second tone**: *rén* rises, like the end of an English question.

Your turn

- *Write it*: 人 — left stroke first, then right. Say *rén* as you finish it.
- *Say it*: **rén**, rising

Before you move on

Which stroke goes first — the one leaning left, or the one leaning right? (The **left**.)

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

2.2 𠂇 — the same person, standing sideways

Write the two-stroke character for *person* once, from memory. Left stroke, then right.

Script — one character, two postures

Every Chinese character is written inside an **evenly sized square block** — whether it has two strokes or twenty, it occupies the same footprint. That one fact drives everything you are about to see.

Because when two pieces have to share a block, one of them must get out of the way. Here is what *person* looks like when it moves to the left edge to make room:

亻

Still two strokes. Still the same piece. But the wide-legged stance has been pulled upright into **one short slant on top of one long vertical**, narrow enough that something else can sit beside it.

This is not a different character. It is the same one, squashed. Chinese does this constantly, and the squashed forms are called **components**. When you see 亻 at the left edge of a block, the character is telling you: *this word is about a person*.

Write it:

1. the **short slant**, down-left, at the top 2. the **long vertical**, dropping from the middle of that slant

Top before bottom — the second of the two rules.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 人, then 亻 beside it. Notice you did not learn a new piece — you learned a new **posture**.
- *Notice:* 亻 is tall and thin because it is only using the left half of its square.

Before you move on

Why does *person* change shape at all? (To leave room in the square for whatever stands beside it.)

Source: Unicode CJK Radicals Supplement chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

2.3 尔 — a piece that is there for its sound

The narrow upright person — draw it once. Short slant, long vertical.

Script — the other kind of component

So far a component has meant something: the person piece says *this is about a person*. Here is a component that works the other way.

尔

尔 ěr. Five strokes: a short slant across the top, a broad cover beneath it, then a small stroke each side of a central vertical that finishes with a hook.

Now the part that matters, and it is the single most useful fact about Chinese writing:

Most characters are built from one component pointing at the MEANING and another pointing at the SOUND. When 尔 turns up inside a character, it is usually there because the word sounds something like ěr — not because the word has anything to do with what 尔 means on its own.

That is a strange idea when your reading habits come from an alphabet, where every piece is sound and none is meaning. It is also a relief: it means characters are not arbitrary pictures to be memorised whole. They are **built**, from a small stock of pieces, and once you know the pieces you can often guess both halves of a character you have never seen.

The pitch is **third tone**: ěr dips low.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 尔 — top slant, cover, then the middle with its hook last
- *Say it:* ěr, low and dipping

Before you move on

Two kinds of component, then. One tells you what a word is **about**; the other tells you roughly how it **sounds**. Which kind is 尔?

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

2.4 Putting two pieces together — and reading the result

Two pieces, both already yours. Draw them side by side:

亻 尔

The narrow person on the left. The five-stroke sound piece on the right.

Script — the assembly

Push them into one square block and you have written a character:

亻 + 尔 → 你

Read it the way you now know how to read it, half at a time:

- the **left** half is the person component. So this word is **about a person**.
- the **right** half is the sound piece ěr. So this word **sounds something like ěr**.

The word is *nǐ*. And that is the honest state of the sound half — *nǐ* and ěr are close, not identical. **A sound component gets you into the neighbourhood, not to the door.** Sound components were chosen over two thousand years of pronunciation change, and the pronunciations moved out from under them. Expect a hint, and you will be right most of the time; expect a rule, and Chinese will embarrass you weekly.

Write it left before right, exactly as you learned each half:

1. 亻 — short slant, long vertical 2. 尔 — top slant, cover, then the middle and its hook

Seven strokes in total, and you did not memorise a single new one.

What you've built

Stop and take the measure of what just happened, because it is the reason this book teaches script this way.

You have not been shown a picture and asked to remember it. You were given two pieces, one at a time, and then shown that a character is what you get when they share a square. **The next character works the same way, and so does the one after that.** There are only a few hundred components in common use, and they recombine — which is what makes several thousand characters a climb rather than a cliff.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 你 — left half first, complete, then the right half
- *Read it:* cover the right half. What does the left half alone tell you?

Before you move on

Two pieces, one block, and a character you can take apart again whenever you need to. Which half would you look at to guess the pronunciation?

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

2.5 女 — three strokes, seated

One character so far assembles from two known halves. Draw it, and name each half as you write it.

Script — the shape

A new piece, and like the first one it is old enough to still look like what it meant:

女

女 *nǚ* — **woman**. Three strokes.

The oracle-bone form is a **kneeling or seated figure with the arms crossed in front**. The modern character keeps the crossing: that long horizontal running right across the middle is the arms, and the two curving strokes beneath and around it are the folded body. It has straightened out over three thousand years, but nothing has been added or taken away.

Write it in this order:

1. the stroke that starts upper-right and **curves down and left** 2. the stroke that crosses it, going **down-left then flicking right** 3. the **long horizontal**, last, sweeping across both

That third stroke going last is worth noticing — a long horizontal that crosses everything else usually waits until the end.

The pitch is **third tone**, and the vowel is the rounded *ü*: say *ee* and then push your lips into a whistle without changing the tongue.

Your turn

- *Write it*: 女 — and let the crossing bar go last
- *Say it*: **nǚ**, low and dipping, lips rounded

Before you move on

Which stroke comes last, and why? (The **long horizontal** — a bar that crosses the whole character usually waits.)

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

2.6 子 — three strokes, a child

Three strokes, crossing bar last. Draw the seated figure you met a moment ago.

Script — the shape

子

子 *zǐ* — **child**. Three strokes again, and again a figure you can still see once you are told where to look.

This one is an infant drawn **from the front**: a large head on top, two arms out to the sides, and the legs bound together so they read as one stroke rather than two. Babies were carried swaddled, and the character kept the bundle.

Write it:

1. the short stroke across the **top**, turning down — the head
2. the **vertical with a hook**, dropping through the middle — the wrapped body
3. the **horizontal** across the middle — the arms

The pitch is **third tone**. The *z* is not the English *z* of *zoo*: it is the *ds* at the end of English *beds*, made with the tongue tip against the teeth.

Your turn

- *Write it*: 子 — head, hooked body, then arms
- *Notice*: two characters now, both three strokes, both once pictures of people. Draw them side by side and compare which parts are curved.

Before you move on

The stroke that runs down the middle carries a hook. What part of the picture is it? (The **wrapped body and legs**.)

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

2.7 Two pieces again — and a warning about the story

Both pieces are yours. Draw them side by side:

女子

Script — the assembly

Squeeze them into one block, woman on the left, child on the right:

女 + 子 → 好

好 *hǎo*. Six strokes, three from each half, and again nothing new.

Note what is **different** about this assembly. The first one you built had a meaning half and a sound half. This one has **two meaning halves and no sound half at all** — neither piece sounds like *hǎo*. Both kinds of character are common, and you cannot tell which kind you are holding until you look.

When 女 is squeezed into the left of a block its long crossing bar stops short rather than sweeping past the middle, so as not to collide with what stands beside it. Same piece, narrower posture — the same accommodation you already saw the person component make.

What you've built — and a caution

You will find it said that 好 means *good* **because** a woman with a child is a good thing.

Treat that as a story, not as evidence. It is memorable, it is repeated everywhere, and there is no agreement among specialists that it is what happened — competing accounts read the woman as the sound half in an older pronunciation, or read the pair as a woman *caring for* a child. This book will hand you an etymology when there is a source behind it and tell you plainly when there is not, and this is one of the second kind.

Use the pairing as a **memory hook**, which it genuinely is. Do not file

it as a fact about why the word means what it means.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 好 — the whole left half first, then the whole right half
- *Notice:* the crossing bar on the left half no longer sweeps all the way across. Why not?

Before you move on

Six strokes, two pieces, and you built both pieces yourself. What is the one claim in this lesson you should NOT repeat as fact?

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

Chapter 3

One to Five — Where the Character Is the Count

Modes:  voice (5)  eyes (1)  pen (5)  Hands-free start: none of the 11 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can count from one to five in Mandarin and read all five characters cold and out of order, and I know which of them I could have worked out and which I simply had to learn.

The five numerals read out of sequence, then off a lift panel with the fourth floor missing — and the reader knows why it is missing.

3.1 — — one stroke, and that is the character

Two chapters ago a character was a block to take apart. You learned pieces first, then the characters they build. This chapter asks nothing of the sort. Put the pieces down.

Script — the whole character

Here it is:

—

That is not a fragment. **That is the character.** One horizontal stroke, drawn left to right across the middle of the square, and nothing else.

Write it: **one héng stroke, left to right.** No pen lifts, because there is nothing to lift between. It is the shortest character you will ever write.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 一 — one stroke, left to right, straight and level

Before you move on

A character you did not have to decompose. How many times did you lift the pen? (**Not once.**)

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

3.2 一 — one, and the number is the strokes

Draw the shape you just learned. One stroke, left to right.

The sounds and tones in this word

一 *yī* means **one**.

Read those two facts together, because their meeting is the point:

One stroke. And it means one.

Chinese will do this exactly three times, and you are about to meet all three in a row. It is the gentlest corner of a writing system with a reputation for being anything but.

Now the sound, and here is something new. Every word this book has given you so far has dipped (*nǐ, hǎo, ěr*) or risen (*rén*). This one does neither.

First tone: high and flat. Start high and stay there — not a question, not a statement, just a held note. Hum a single steady pitch and put *yī* on it. *Twice through:*

One honest note, so it does not surprise you later. 一 **does not always keep this tone.** In front of certain syllables it shifts to *yí* or *yì* — the same kind of change that turned 你好 into *nǐ hǎo*. Counting is exactly where it stays *yī*, so counting is where this book leaves it.

Your turn

- *Say it:* yī — high and flat, held
- *Read it:* 一 — say it, then say how many strokes it has

Before you move on

Which tone is $yī$ — the dipping one, or the flat one? (**Flat**, held high.)

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

3.3 二 — two bars, and neither is decoration

Draw the character for one. Now guess what two looks like before you read on.

Script — you were right

二

Two strokes, both horizontal, and the order is the one this book has repeated since the person radical: **top before bottom**.

But look properly, because they are **not the same length**:

- the **upper** bar is the **shorter** one
- the **lower** bar is the **longer** one

That is not decoration. A character occupies a square, and two identical bars floating in one look like an accident. The widening bottom gives the block a base to sit on. You will meet the same instinct everywhere: the last horizontal tends to be the widest, because it is the one holding everything up.

Write it: **short bar. Lift. Long bar beneath.**

Your turn

- *Write it:* 二 — short bar on top, then the long one below

Before you move on

Two strokes for two. Which goes first? (The **top**.)

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

3.4 二 — two, and a syllable you have met before

Draw the shape. Two bars, short over long. Count the strokes and say what number you expect it to be.

The sounds and tones in this word

二 *èr* means **two**. Two strokes, and it means two — the pattern holds. **èr** is **fourth tone**, the last of the four you had not used in a real word. Fourth tone **falls**, sharply and from a height, the way an English speaker says a short firm “*No*.” Drop it, do not trail it. [REPEAT x2] Now hold **èr** next to a piece you already know:

尔 *ěr* — the sound-component inside 你

>

二 *èr* — the number two

Same syllable. Different tone. Completely unrelated characters. One dips; one falls. Nothing else separates them. You met this idea once already, when 好 *hǎo* “good” turned into 好 *hào* “fond of” on a change of pitch alone. That was one character with two readings; this is two characters colliding in sound. Both are the same lesson: **in Mandarin the pitch is not decoration on the word. It is part of the word.**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- **èr** — falling, dropped firmly
- **ěr**, then **èr** — dip, then fall. Feel the difference in your throat.
- **yī**, **èr** — flat, then down

Before you move on

What separates *ěr* from *èr*? (**Only the tone** — and they are different characters entirely.)

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

3.5 三 — three bars, and the pattern's last stand

One bar. Two bars. Say what comes next out loud before you look.

Script — the pattern holds one last time

三

Three strokes. Top, then middle, then bottom — the same rule, a third time.

The lengths are not a simple ladder:

- the **top** bar is medium
- the **middle** bar is the **shortest** of the three
- the **bottom** bar is by far the **longest**

Pinching the middle and widening the base keeps 三 from reading as three identical lines you would have to stop and count. Your eye takes it in whole. That is the difference between a **character** and a **tally** — and the reason the next one cannot be four bars.

Write it: **top, lift, middle, lift, bottom.** Two pen lifts.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 三 — top, middle short, bottom long
- *Read it:* 一 二 三 — point at each and count its strokes

Before you move on

Imagine four bars stacked in a square. Could you read it, or would you have to **count** it? (Count it — which is why the next character is not four bars.)

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

3.6 三 — three, and the end of the easy road

Draw the three bars. Middle short, bottom long.

The sounds and tones in this word

≡ *sān* means **three**. Three strokes, three — for the third and last time.

sān is **first tone**, the flat high one you met on *yī*. Hold it level. The *a* is open, the *n* light at the end. [REPEAT x2]

So of your first three numbers, two sit flat and one falls:

yī flat, **èr** falling, **sān** flat

Say the run. It goes *level, down, level*, and that shape is the first thing a listener recognises — before any of the individual words.

Why it's said this way

Three characters in, one stroke per unit, a system so regular it barely needs teaching. **It stops here**, and you should know why before it happens.

Every counting system humans have built hits the same wall in the same place. Roman numerals go I, II, III and then break to IV, because stacked marks stop being readable at about three. This one breaks for exactly the same reason.

You are being told now so that the next character feels like a solved problem rather than a broken promise.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **yī**, **èr**, **sān** — level, down, level
- *Read it:* — 一 二 三 — say each as you point at it

Before you move on

Three characters, three stroke counts, nothing memorised. That ends now.

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

3.7 四 — a box, and the rule that governs every box

Draw one, two and three. You were told this is where it stops.

Script — five strokes, for four

四

Five strokes, for the number four. The trick is gone, exactly as promised.

四 is a **box with two things inside it**, and every box obeys one rule: **close the bottom LAST**. Walls, then contents, then shut the door.

In order:

1. the **left vertical**, top to bottom
2. the **top and right side in one turning stroke** — across, then down without lifting the pen at the corner
3. the short **inner left-falling** stroke
4. the **inner stroke that turns up** at its foot
5. the **bottom bar**, closing the box — **last**

Two strokes of wall, two of filling, one to shut the door. Four pen lifts.

Notice that the corner in step 2 is **one stroke, not two**. A horizontal that turns and runs downward without the pen leaving the paper is a single unit — *héngzhé*, “horizontal-turn”. Miscounting it is the commonest way a beginner’s stroke count goes wrong.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 四 — walls, then the two inner strokes, then the bottom last

Before you move on

Is the turning corner one stroke or two? (**One** — *héngzhé*.)

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

3.8 四 — four, borrowed for its sound

Draw the box. Walls, contents, bottom last. Count the strokes: five, for the number four.

The sounds and tones in this word

四 *sì* means **four**, and the shape has nothing to do with fourness.

四 is not a picture of four things. It is a shape that already meant something else, **borrowed for its sound** — the same move you met in 尔, a piece carried for how it sounds rather than what it means. The borrowing won outright: nobody reads 四 as anything but four now.

sì is **fourth tone**, falling, like *èr*. The vowel is not the *ee* of “see”: after *s*, pinyin *i* is a tight buzz in the same position as the *s* itself. Say *sss*, then voice it without moving your tongue. [REPEAT x2]

Why it’s said this way

A reason to get that tone right, and it is a real one:

sì (falling) — four

>

sǐ (dipping) — die

Separated **by pitch alone** — the third time this chapter has shown you that tone is part of a Mandarin word’s identity, not an accent on it. Not a curiosity, either: it is why many buildings in China number floors 1, 2, 3, 5, skipping four the way some Western buildings skip thirteen.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **sì** — falling, firm
- *Read it:* 一 二 三 四 — in order, then out of order

Before you move on

Four is the first number here you could not work out. What replaced the trick? (**A shape borrowed for its sound**, built to a rule.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

3.9 五 — count the strokes and be wrong

Guess, out loud, how many strokes the character for five will have.

Script — four, for five

五

Four strokes. For five.

If you guessed five, good — that guess is the point. The trick that carried you through the first three is not merely retired, it now actively misleads.

The four strokes, in order:

1. the **top horizontal**, left to right 2. the **descending stroke**, from the top bar down, leaning slightly left 3. the **turning stroke** — across to the right, then down 4. the **bottom horizontal**, the widest in the character, closing it

You already know why the last is widest: it is the base, the same instinct as the long bottom bar of 二 and 三. Three pen lifts.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 五 — top bar, descender, turn, then the wide base
- *Read it:* 一 二 三 四 五 — name each shape without saying the numbers yet

Before you move on

Which stroke is widest, and why? (The **bottom** — it is the base.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

3.10 五 — five, and the run is complete

Draw the shape. Four strokes — for five.

The sounds and tones in this word

五 *wǔ* means **five**.

wǔ is **third tone**, the low dipping one you have had since *nǐ*. Keep it low and let it creak; do not push it back up. [REPEAT x2]

You already own two words on this tone:

你 *nǐ*, 好 *hǎo*, 五 *wǔ*

All three dip. Say them in a row: the pitch should not change shape once, only the mouth around it.

One spelling note while you are here. In *wǔ* there is no consonant hiding under that **w**: the *w* is the *u*, written that way because pinyin does not begin a syllable with a bare *u*. Round your lips and voice it.

What you've built — one to five

You can now count:

一 二 三 四 五

>

yī, èr, sān, sì, wǔ

Say it as one run, not five separate words. The tone shape is **level, down, level, down, dip**, and that rhythm is what a listener hears first.

Five characters, and three ways one can come to you: two you derived, one was borrowed for its sound, and two you simply learned. That mix is Chinese writing in miniature, and you have now met all of it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- **nǐ, hǎo, wǔ** — three dips, one shape
- **yī èr sān sì wǔ** — one run, at speed

Before you move on

Which tone do *nǐ*, *hǎo* and *wǔ* share? (The **third** — low and dipping.)

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

3.11 Practice — read the numbers off a wall

Count to five aloud, in order, without looking. Then do it again with your eyes on the characters:

一 二 三 四 五

Script — the same five, shuffled

Counting in order is slightly dishonest: the sequence carries you, and you can recite *yī èr sān* without reading anything.

So here they are shuffled. Name each before moving on, without letting your eye run back to the row above:

四 一 五 二 三

>

三 五 一 四 二

If one of them made you pause, it will be 四 or 五 — the two you could not derive. That is expected, and it tells you exactly which two to drill.

Why it's said this way

Not a party trick. A lift panel, a floor directory, a bus number, a market price — all use these characters **on their own**, with no sentence around them. That is why five are already useful; you are not waiting on grammar:

You see: 三

>

You say: *sān* — third floor.

And when the panel reads

一 二 三 五

with no 四 between three and five, you know why, and you are not confused by it.

The exchange

Two voices, using only what this book has given you:

A: 你好 — *ní hǎo* (the sandhi tone, as always)

>

B: 你好 — *ní hǎo*

>

A: [pointing at a panel] 五 — *wǔ*

>

B: 五 — *wǔ*

Small, and entirely real: repeating a floor number back is what people do in a lift, in any language.

Your turn

- *Read it:* 四 — 五 二 三 — cover the row above first
- *Say it:* *yī èr sān sì wǔ* — one run, level, down, level, down, dip
- *Write it:* 五 — top bar, descender, turn, wide base

What you've built this chapter

Five characters, and three different ways a character can come to you:

- 一 二 三 — transparent. The strokes *are* the number.
- 四 — borrowed for its sound, and built on a box whose rule you can reuse.
- 五 — plain. Four strokes for five, learned as a shape.

That spread is not an accident of this chapter. It is the whole writing system in small: a little of it can be reasoned out, more of it is borrowed sound, and the rest is simply known. You have now met all three, on characters short enough that none of them hurt.

Before you move on

You can read the five characters cold, in any order, with no sentence around them. A panel reads 一 二 三 五 — which number is missing, and why? (四, because *sì* sits one tone from *sǐ*.)

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

Chapter 4

One Box, Two Characters, and the First Thing You Can Refuse

Modes: 🗣️ voice (3) 👁️ eyes (1) ✍️ pen (3) 🗣️ Hands-free start: none of the 7 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can write 口 and 日 – the second being the first with one bar added – and I can disagree in Mandarin by putting 不 in front of a word I already know, because Mandarin has no standalone word for no.

The first exchange in the book that contains a disagreement – a greeting, a question, and a refusal built by negating a word the reader has had since the opening lesson.

4.1 口 — the box, on its own

Write 四. Walls, then the two inner strokes, then the bottom last.

Script — the shape

口

Your hand can already write this. Three strokes, in exactly the order you learned inside 四, and the rule from there is the whole instruction:

1. the **left vertical**, top to bottom 2. the **top and right side in one turning stroke** — the *héngzhé*, across then down without lifting 3. the **bottom bar**, closing it — **last**

Three strokes, two pen lifts. Walls, then the door.

One honest note, because it will save you trouble later. The enclosing frame around 四 and this character are **not the same piece**, even though they are written identically. Chinese has a separate enclosure component that does the surrounding, and 口 is a character in its own right. What transfers here is the hand movement, not the identity — and the hand movement is most of the work.

Your turn

Write these out:

- 口 — left wall, turning stroke, bottom last
- 四, then 口 — the same movement, two different pieces

Before you move on

How many strokes? (**Three** — the turning corner counts as one.)
Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

4.2 口 — mouth, and a piece you will meet everywhere

Draw the box. Three strokes, bottom last.

The sounds and tones in this word

口 *kǒu* means **mouth**.

Look at it again now that it means something. **It is an open mouth, seen from the front** — squared off, the way every Chinese character is squared off to fit its block, but a picture all the same. The oldest forms are rounder and even more obviously a mouth.

kǒu is **third tone**, the low dipping one you have had since *nǚ*. Keep it low. [REPEAT x2]

Why it's said this way

You have already met pieces that live inside other characters — 女 and 子 sit inside 好. 口 is the commonest of them all. When you see it as a

small element in a corner of a bigger character, it very often says the word has something to do with the **mouth**: speaking, eating, calling, tasting.

The size matters. A full-height frame around a whole character is a different piece doing a different job; the mouth hint is for the small one tucked into a corner.

That is worth more than the word itself. You are not going to memorise five thousand characters as pictures; you are going to learn a few hundred pieces and read the rest as combinations. 𠃊 is one of the commonest pieces there is.

Your turn

- *Say it:* kǒu — low and dipping
- *Write it:* 𠃊 — and say what it is a picture of

Before you move on

If you meet this box inside a bigger character, what does it usually hint at? (Something to do with the **mouth**.)

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

4.3 𠃊 — one bar inside the box

Draw the box. Now hold it in your head; you are about to fill it.

Script — the shape

𠃊

The same box, with one horizontal bar across the middle. That is the entire difference, and it buys you a second character.

Four strokes, and the order has one thing worth getting right:

1. the **left vertical** 2. the **top and right side**, one turning stroke 3. the **middle bar** 4. the **bottom bar**, closing it — still last

The middle bar goes in before the bottom. Fill the box, then shut it. That is the same instinct as the box rule itself, applied one level in: you never close a space you still have to write inside.

Three pen lifts. If your box was comfortable, this cost you one line.

Your turn

Write these out:

- □, then 日 — the same four movements plus one
- 日 — and check that the middle bar went in before the bottom

Before you move on

How many strokes separate this character from the box? (**One.**)
 Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

4.4 日 — the sun, and the day it measures

Write the box, then the box with a bar. Two characters, one shape.

The sounds and tones in this word

日 *rì* means **sun** — and also **day**.

The picture is the sun: a disc with a mark in the middle. Squared off, like everything else, but that is what the bar is doing there. The oldest forms are a circle with a dot.

rì is **fourth tone**, falling. The *r* is not an English *r* and not a Spanish one either: start where your tongue sits for the *s* in English *measure*, then **curl the tip back** a little. Let the vowel be short and tight.

Twice through:

Why it's said this way

Sun and **day** in the same word is not a Chinese quirk. It is what happens in language after language, because the sun is how a day was counted before anybody had a clock. English does the same thing from the other end: we say *the sun rose* and *three days later*, and nobody finds it strange that a *day* is both the light and the span.

So this is one of the rare characters where you get two meanings and have to learn neither: they are the same idea, and the context tells you which.

Like □, this one turns up **inside** other characters, and when it does it is almost always about the sun, light, or time.

Your turn

- *Say it:* り — falling, and the *r* of *measure*
- *Write it:* 日 — and say both of its meanings

Before you move on

If you meet this shape inside a bigger character, what is it hinting at? (**Sun, light or time.**)

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

4.5 丌 — four strokes, all of them separate

Write 日. Middle bar before the bottom.

Script — the shape

丌

Four strokes, in this order:

1. a **top horizontal**, left to right
2. lift, then a **long stroke from the upper centre down to the left**
3. lift, then the **central vertical**, straight down
4. lift, then a **short right-falling dot**

Three pen lifts, and every stroke stands alone. Nothing joins here. That is unusual enough to be worth saying plainly: the boxes you have just written were one continuous movement in places, and this is the opposite — four deliberate, separate marks under a single roof.

The commonest beginner's version runs the second and third strokes together into a corner. They are not a corner. Lift.

Your turn

Write these out:

- 丌 — top bar, the long left-falling stroke, the vertical, the dot
- it again, counting the lifts aloud. There should be three.

Before you move on

Do the second and third strokes meet in a corner? (**No** — lift between them.)

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

4.6 不 — how Mandarin says no

Write 不, counting three lifts. Then say **hǎo** — good.

The sounds and tones in this word

不 *bù* means **not**.

bù is **fourth tone**, falling — the same firm drop you learned on *èr* and *sì*. [REPEAT x2]

Grammar Lens: there is no word for “no”

Here is something that surprises nearly every learner, and it is better met now than discovered later.

Mandarin has no single word meaning “no.”

English has one. So does French, Spanish, Russian. Mandarin does not. What it has instead is 不, which goes in front of a word and turns it around:

好 *hǎo* — good

>

不好 *bù hǎo* — not good

So when someone asks you a yes-or-no question in Mandarin, you do not answer with a word for “no”. **You answer by negating the thing they asked about.** Ask whether something is 好, and “no” comes back as 不好.

This sounds like extra work and is actually less: you already know 好, so you already know how to refuse it, and the same holds for every word you have so far.

One word will break the pattern later — Mandarin has a second negator for *having*, and you will meet it with the word it belongs to. Everything in this book up to now takes 不.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **bù** — falling, firm
- *Say it:* **hǎo**, then **bù hǎo** — good, then not good
- *Write it:* 不好

Before you move on

You have known 好 since the first lesson. How much did its opposite cost you? (**One character.**)

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

4.7 Practice — one box, two characters, and a refusal

Write 口. Then write 日. One line apart.

The exchange

Two voices, using only what you have:

A: 你好

>

ní hǎo

>

B: 你好

>

ní hǎo

>

A: 好

>

hǎo — good?

>

B: 不好

>

bù hǎo — not good.

Small, and it is the first time in this book you have been able to **disagree**. Up to now every exchange has been agreement: a greeting answered by the same greeting, a number read back. This one has a no in it.

What you've built this chapter

Three characters, and not one of them cost what it looks like it cost:

- 口 *kǒu*, mouth — you already knew the shape; it is the box from the number four, standing on its own
- 日 *rì*, sun and day — the same box with one bar added
- 不 *bù*, not — four separate strokes, and it turns every word you own into its opposite

That last one is the largest thing in the chapter. 不 **does not add one word to your vocabulary; it doubles what you already have**. Everything you have learned to say so far, you have now learned to refuse.

And the two boxes are a down payment of a different kind. 口 and 日 both turn up **inside** other characters — mouth for speaking and eating, sun for light and time — so the next character that contains one will already be half read.

Your turn

- *Read it:* 口 日 不 — name each one, then say what it means
- *Write it:* 日 — and check the middle bar went in before the bottom
- *Say it:* **hǎo**, then **bù hǎo**

Before you move on

Which two of this chapter's characters share a shape? (𠂇 and 𠂈.)

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

Chapter 5

Yes, No, and a Tone That Moves

Modes: ☞ voice (3) ✍ pen (1) ☞ Hands-free start: none of the 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can write 是 by finishing 日 before the body underneath, answer a yes-or-no question either way by keeping or negating the word I was asked about, and apply the rule that 不 rises before a falling tone even though the writing never shows it.

The first exchange in which the reader can answer either way – 是 for yes, 不是 for no – and hear the negator's pitch rise on a page that records no such thing.

5.1 是 — finish the sun, then build under it

Write 日. Four strokes, middle bar before the bottom.

Script — the shape

是

Nine strokes. That is more than double anything you have written, and it is the point at which counting strokes stops being useful and structure takes over.

Here is the structure, and it makes the character easy: 是 is 日 **sitting on top of a body.** You have written the top already.

1-4. 日, **complete.** Left vertical; top and right in one turning stroke; the middle bar; the bottom bar closing it. Exactly as you learned it.

Then, underneath:

5. a **wide horizontal**, wider than the 日 above it 6. a **central vertical** coming down 7. a **short horizontal** at the lower right 8. a **falling stroke** to the lower left 9. a **long finishing stroke** down to the right

Finish 日 before you begin the body. This is the same instinct as the box rule and the middle bar: complete an enclosed unit before moving on. Chinese stroke order is a small number of habits applied over and over, and you now have three of them.

Eight pen lifts. Take it slowly; nobody writes this quickly at first.

Your turn

Write these out:

- 日 on its own, then 是 — and notice the first four strokes are identical
- 是 again, saying “sun first” before you start

Before you move on

How many of the nine strokes did you already know? (**Four.**)

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart; stroke order per the PRC standard *Xiandai Hanyu Tongyongzi Bishun Guifan* (1997).

5.2 是 — “is”, and the nearest thing to “yes”

Write 是. Sun first, then the body.

The sounds and tones in this word

是 *shì* means **is** — am, is, are, all one word with no changes for person or number.

shì is **fourth tone**, falling. The initial is the same retroflex position you met on *rì*: tongue tip curled back, and this time unvoiced — closer to the *sh* of English *shirt* than to *s*. [REPEAT x2]

Grammar Lens: yes by echo

You already know that Mandarin has no single word for **no** — you negate the word you were asked about. The other half of that rule is now available to you:

Mandarin has no single word for “yes” either. You echo the

word back.

Asked whether something 是, you answer 是. That is the yes. It is not a separate word meaning agreement; it is the word you were asked about, returned.

It is not the *only* way Mandarin says yes — spoken Mandarin has other affirmatives you will meet in time. It is the one that follows from what you already know, and the one that works whenever the question hands you a word to give back.

Neither half of the pair is the word an English speaker goes looking for. This is worth holding onto, because it is the shape of a great many Mandarin answers: **the reply is the question's own word, kept or turned.** You have the keeping half now; the turning half is the next lesson, and you already own the character it needs.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **shì** — falling, tongue curled back
- *Say it:* **shì** as an answer meaning “yes”
- *Write it:* 是

Before you move on

What is the yes, asked about 是? (是 — the same word, returned.)

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

5.3 不是 — “is not”, and the second tone that moves

Say **shì**. Then say **bù**. Both fall.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of**不是**

Nothing new on the page: 不 in front of 是, exactly the rule you already have. It means **is not**.

But say the two words you just warmed up with, one after the other, and something is wrong. **bù** falls. **shì** falls. Two sharp drops in a row,

back to back, and your mouth does not want to make them.

Why it's said this way

Mandarin does not make you do it. 不 **changes its own tone rather than collide.**

written: 不是 — *bù + shì*

>

spoken: **bú shì** — *bú* rises

不 **becomes second tone, rising, whenever a fourth tone follows it.** Before anything else it stays *bù*, falling — which is why 不好 was *bù hǎo*, unchanged, with 好 in the third tone.

You have met this exact machinery once before. When two third tones met in 你好, the first one moved and became rising, so *nǐ hǎo* came out as *ní hǎo*. Same problem, same kind of solution: **when two tones would clash, the first one gives way, and the spelling never records it.**

That is the **second** rule of this kind you have been taught in full, and both share one warning: **the page will not tell you.** You were also warned about a third, on 一, which shifts its own tone in front of certain syllables — that one is still waiting, and it will arrive with the words that need it. 不是 is written with the falling-tone 不 every time. The change lives in the mouth, and you have to carry it yourself.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- **bù**, then **shì**, deliberately clashing. Hear why it is awkward.
- **bú shì** — the first one rising now
- **bù hǎo**, then **bú shì** — falling, then rising, and say why

Before you move on

Does the writing change when the tone does? (**No** — 不是 is written the same way every time.)

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

5.4 Practice — answering either way

Write 是. Sun first, then the body underneath.

The exchange

Two voices, and for the first time the second one has a real choice:

A: 你好

>

ní hǎo

>

B: 你好

>

ní hǎo

>

A: 是

>

shì — is it?

>

B: 是

>

shì — yes.

And the same exchange, refused:

A: 是

>

shì

>

B: 不是

>

bú shì — no.

Say the last line twice and listen to the first syllable. It **rises**. Write it and it falls. That gap between the page and the mouth is the whole lesson.

What you've built this chapter

One character, and with it both answers.

是 is nine strokes, the longest thing you have written — but four of them were 日, finished before the body began, and that is why it was manageable. The habit of completing an enclosed piece before moving on has now carried you through a box, a box with a bar, and a nine-stroke character built on top of one.

And the pair is closed. Mandarin gives you neither a word for yes nor a word for no; it gives you one word and two things to do with it. 是 keeps it. 不是 turns it. Every yes-or-no answer you learn from here will work the same way.

The tone rule is the part to carry away, because nothing on the page will remind you: 不 **rises before a falling tone**. That is the second such rule taught in full, after the one on 你好, and a third — on 一 — has been flagged and not yet taught. Every one of them is invisible in the writing.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **shì**, then **bú shì** — yes, then no
- *Say it:* **bù hǎo**, then **bú shì** — and say which one moved, and why
- *Write it:* 是, then 不是

Before you move on

Do either of the rules you have been taught show up in the writing?
(**Neither.**)

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

Pronunciation & Character Guide

Reference material, never a gate. Every lesson teaches the sounds its own word needs, inline, and links here for anyone who wants the fuller picture. Nobody has to read this page before Lesson 1, and most readers never will.

The ids in each heading are the values a lesson's **sounds**: frontmatter list points at.

Why this page is different from every other track's

In an alphabetic or abugida track, “the sounds you’ll need” is a list of *segments*: this letter is silent, that vowel is long, this consonant is retroflex. Each fact is attached to a letter, and the letter is on the page.

Mandarin adds a second, orthogonally different kind of fact. **Tone** rides on a whole syllable, is not written in the characters at all, and is *phonemic* — it distinguishes words the way a consonant does. A segmental note cannot express it. So this page has two halves: tones first, because they are the part an English speaker has no instinct for, then the segments.

The machine-readable form of the first half lives in the Chinese script reference under **tones** and **toneSandhi**.

Tones

Mandarin has four tones plus a neutral one. Pinyin writes the tone as a mark over the vowel; the characters do not record it anywhere.

The classic demonstration uses one syllable, *ma*:

- **tone-1** — first, high level (contour 55). Held high and flat, one steady note. *mā* — mother.
- **tone-2** — second, rising (35). Climbs from mid to high, like the pitch on a surprised English “huh?”. *má* — hemp.

- **tone-3** — third, dipping (214). Sinks low and creaky; said alone it rises again a little at the end, but in running speech it usually just stays low. *mǎ* — horse.
- **tone-4** — fourth, falling (51). Drops sharply from high to low, like a clipped “No!”. *mà* — to scold.
- **tone-neutral** — unstressed. Short and light, with no mark written at all, pitched by whatever came before it. *ma* — a question particle.

tone-lexical — tone is part of the word

The single fact that matters most, taught in the first lesson: changing the pitch of a Mandarin syllable changes **which word it is**, not how you feel about it. *mā*, *má*, *mǎ* and *mà* are four separate words. English uses pitch for mood and emphasis only, so this is a genuinely new job for an English speaker’s voice.

tone-sandhi-third — two third tones in a row

When a third tone is followed by another third tone, the first is spoken as a rising second tone.

Written **nǐ hǎo**, said **ní hǎo**. Neither the pinyin nor the characters record the change; dictionaries print the citation tone each word carries alone. This is why a reader who trusts only the page mispronounces the commonest greeting in the language.

tone-sandhi-bu — 不 before a fourth tone

不 *bù* is said *bú* when the next syllable has a fourth tone: *bù shì* → *bú shì*. Recorded here for completeness; no Chapter 1 lesson needs it.

Segments

Pinyin is a romanization, not English spelling. A few letters do work you would not guess.

- **pinyin-n** — as in English *no*.
- **pinyin-i** — after most consonants, the *ee* of “see”. (After *z-*, *c-*, *s-*, *zh-*, *ch-*, *sh-*, *r-* it is a different, buzzier vowel; no Chapter 1 word uses those.)

- pinyin-*h* — rougher than English *h*, scraped at the back of the mouth, closer to the *ch* of Scottish *loch* softened.
- pinyin-*ao* — one gliding vowel, the *ow* of “how”. Not two syllables.

The characters themselves

Stroke shapes, components, and stroke order for every character this track has introduced live in Chinese script reference. Unlike the Indic scripts in this curriculum, where stroke order is conventional, Chinese stroke order is a **taught, standardised system** — top before bottom, left before right, horizontal before vertical, outside before inside, and close a box last. That file marks its stroke orders **authoritative** for exactly that reason.

Glossary

This glossary collects every word and phrase taught in the book. Pronunciation appears when it differs from the written form; chapter numbers show where each entry is introduced.

不 *bù*

not — the character that turns a word around

Introduced in Chapter 4.

不是 *bú shì*

is not — and a pitch that moves to get out of the way

Introduced in Chapter 5.

二 *èr*

two

Introduced in Chapter 3.

好 *hǎo*

good, well

Introduced in Chapter 1.

口 *kǒu*

mouth

Introduced in Chapter 4.

你 *nǐ*

you (one person)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

你好 *nǐ hǎo*

hello (literally “you good”)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

日 *rì*

sun, and also day

Introduced in Chapter 4.

三 *sān*

three

Introduced in Chapter 3.

是 *shì*

to be — and how Mandarin says yes
Introduced in Chapter 5.

四 *sì*

four

Introduced in Chapter 3.

五 *wǔ*

five

Introduced in Chapter 3.

一 *yī*

one

Introduced in Chapter 3.

Review Questions

Try these without looking ahead. Every prompt comes from the same canonical lesson data as its chapter. Answers begin in the next section.

Chapter 1

1.1 *mā má mǎ mà — one syllable, four words*

How many marked tones does Mandarin have, not counting the neutral one? Type the number as a word.

1.2 你 — “you”, and the first character

Type the Mandarin word, in pinyin with its tone mark, that means ‘you’ (one person).

1.3 好 — “good”, and what replaces etymology here

好 is built from two components. Type the meaning of the one on the left.

1.4 你好 — the greeting, assembled from two things you already have

You have just been introduced to someone. Type the Mandarin greeting in characters.

1.5 *nǐ hǎo — why the greeting is not said the way it is written*

A dictionary prints the greeting as nǐ hǎo. Type it in pinyin the way it is actually spoken.

1.6 好 again — proof, on a character you own, that tone is the word

Read in the falling fourth tone, 好 stops meaning ‘good’. Type its meaning with that tone, in English.

1.7 Practice — greet someone, and be greeted back

Someone greets you with 你好. Type your reply in characters.

Chapter 2

2.1 人 — two strokes, and a person walking

How many strokes does the character for ‘person’ have?

2.2 亻 — *the same person, standing sideways*

A character has the narrow upright person component at its left edge. What does that tell you about the word?

2.3 尔 — *a piece that is there for its sound*

When a component is inside a character for its SOUND rather than its meaning, what is it telling you?

2.4 *Putting two pieces together — and reading the result*

In this character, which half points at the MEANING — the left or the right?

2.5 女 — *three strokes, seated*

How many strokes are in the character for 'woman'?

2.6 子 — *three strokes, a child*

What does the three-stroke character with the hooked vertical and a bar across the middle mean?

2.7 *Two pieces again — and a warning about the story*

Does this character have a component that points at its pronunciation?

Chapter 3

3.1 一 — *one stroke, and that is the character*

How many strokes does the character for one have?

3.2 一 — *one, and the number is the strokes*

What is the relationship between the number of strokes in this character and what it means?

3.3 二 — *two bars, and neither is decoration*

In the character for two, which bar is longer — the top or the bottom?

3.4 二 — *two, and a syllable you have met before*

Type the pinyin, with its tone mark, for the number two.

3.5 三 — *three bars, and the pattern's last stand*

In the character for three, which of the three bars is shortest?

3.6 三 — *three, and the end of the easy road*

Do you expect the character for four to have four strokes? Why or why not?

3.7 四 — *a box, and the rule that governs every box*

Which stroke of the box in the character for four is drawn LAST?

3.8 四 — *four, borrowed for its sound*

Why do some buildings in China have no fourth floor?

3.9 五 — *count the strokes and be wrong*

How many strokes does the character for five have?

3.10 五 — *five, and the run is complete*

Which of the five numbers could you have worked out from their strokes alone?

3.11 Practice — *read the numbers off a wall*

A lift panel reads 一 二 三 五. Which floor number is missing, and why?

Chapter 4

4.1 口 — *the box, on its own*

Which stroke of this box is written last?

4.2 口 — *mouth, and a piece you will meet everywhere*

What does this character mean, and what is it a picture of?

4.3 日 — *one bar inside the box*

Does the middle bar go in before or after the bottom bar?

4.4 日 — *the sun, and the day it measures*

This character means two things. What are they, and why are they the same word?

4.5 不 — *four strokes, all of them separate*

How many times do you lift the pen writing this character?

4.6 不 — *how Mandarin says no*

Mandarin has no single word meaning 'no'. So how do you answer no to a yes-or-no question?

4.7 Practice — *one box, two characters, and a refusal*

Why is 不 worth more than one word of vocabulary?

Chapter 5

5.1 是 — *finish the sun, then build under it*

Which character sits on top of this one, and must be finished first?

5.2 是 — *“is”, and the nearest thing to “yes”*

Mandarin has no separate word for 'yes'. So how do you say it?

5.3 不是 — *“is not”, and the second tone that moves*

不 changes tone before one particular kind of syllable. Which, and what does 不 become?

5.4 Practice — *answering either way*

Mandarin gives you no word for yes and none for no. What does it give you instead?

Answer Key

The first response is the canonical display answer. When a question accepts other authored forms, they appear underneath.

Chapter 1

1.1 *mā má mǎ mà — one syllable, four words*

Answer: four

Also accepted: 4

1.2 你 — “you”, and the first character

Answer: nǐ

Also accepted: ni3; ni

1.3 好 — “good”, and what replaces etymology here

Answer: woman

Also accepted: female; 女

1.4 你好 — the greeting, assembled from two things you already have

Answer: 你好

Also accepted: ni hao; nǐ hǎo; ní hǎo; nihao

1.5 ní hǎo — why the greeting is not said the way it is written

Answer: ní hǎo

Also accepted: ni2 hao3; nihao (ní hǎo); ní hao

1.6 好 again — proof, on a character you own, that tone is the word

Answer: to be fond of

Also accepted: to like; like; fond of; be fond of

1.7 Practice — greet someone, and be greeted back

Answer: 你好

Also accepted: ni hao; nǐ hǎo; ní hǎo; nihao

Chapter 2

2.1 人 — *two strokes, and a person walking*

Answer: 2

Also accepted: two; 2 strokes; two strokes

2.2 亻 — *the same person, standing sideways*

Answer: it is about a person

Also accepted: person; about a person; it involves a person; people

2.3 尔 — *a piece that is there for its sound*

Answer: roughly how the word is pronounced

Also accepted: the pronunciation; how it sounds; the sound; how to say it

2.4 Putting two pieces together — *and reading the result*

Answer: the left

Also accepted: left; left half; the left half

2.5 女 — *three strokes, seated*

Answer: 3

Also accepted: three; 3 strokes; three strokes

2.6 子 — *three strokes, a child*

Answer: child

Also accepted: a child; baby; kid; child, zi

2.7 Two pieces again — *and a warning about the story*

Answer: no

Also accepted: none; neither; no it does not

Chapter 3

3.1 一 — *one stroke, and that is the character*

Answer: 1

Also accepted: one; 1 stroke; one stroke

3.2 一 — *one, and the number is the strokes*

Answer: they are the same

Also accepted: they are the same number; one stroke means one; the same; stroke count equals the number; they match

3.3 二 — *two bars, and neither is decoration*

Answer: the bottom

Also accepted: bottom; lower; the lower one; bottom bar

3.4 二 — *two, and a syllable you have met before*

Answer: èr

Also accepted: er4; er

3.5 三 — *three bars, and the pattern's last stand*

Answer: the middle one

Also accepted: middle; the middle; middle bar; the middle bar; 2nd; second

3.6 三 — *three, and the end of the easy road***Answer:** no**Also accepted:** four bars would be unreadable; you would have to count it; stacked bars stop being readable**3.7** 四 — *a box, and the rule that governs every box***Answer:** the bottom**Also accepted:** bottom; the bottom bar; bottom bar; closing the bottom; the closing bottom stroke**3.8** 四 — *four, borrowed for its sound***Answer:** si sounds like the word for die**Also accepted:** because si sounds like die; four sounds like death; si and si differ only by tone; it sounds like the word for death**3.9** 五 — *count the strokes and be wrong***Answer:** 4**Also accepted:** four; 4 strokes; four strokes**3.10** 五 — *five, and the run is complete***Answer:** one two and three**Also accepted:** 1 2 3; one, two, three; the first three; 一 二 三; yi er san**3.11** Practice — *read the numbers off a wall***Answer:** four**Also accepted:** 4; 四; four, because si sounds like the word for die; four - sounds like die; 4 - unlucky

Chapter 4

4.1 口 — *the box, on its own***Answer:** the bottom**Also accepted:** bottom; the bottom bar; bottom bar; closing the bottom**4.2** 口 — *mouth, and a piece you will meet everywhere***Answer:** mouth**Also accepted:** a mouth; an open mouth; mouth - it is a picture of one**4.3** 日 — *one bar inside the box***Answer:** before**Also accepted:** before it; before the bottom; the middle comes first**4.4** 日 — *the sun, and the day it measures***Answer:** sun and day**Also accepted:** sun and day - the sun measures the day; sun, day; the sun and the day it counts**4.5** 丌 — *four strokes, all of them separate***Answer:** 3**Also accepted:** three; 3 times; three times

4.6 不 — *how Mandarin says no***Answer:** negate the word they asked about**Also accepted:** by negating the verb; put bu in front of the word; negate what was asked; say bu plus the word**4.7 Practice** — *one box, two characters, and a refusal***Answer:** it negates every word you know**Also accepted:** it doubles your vocabulary; it turns any word into its opposite; every word gets a negative

Chapter 5

5.1 是 — *finish the sun, then build under it***Answer:** the sun character**Also accepted:** 日; rì; the sun; sun**5.2 是** — *“is”, and the nearest thing to “yes”***Answer:** echo the word back**Also accepted:** repeat it; say it again; echo the word you were asked about**5.3 不是** — *“is not”, and the second tone that moves***Answer:** before a fourth tone it becomes rising**Also accepted:** before a falling tone, it rises; before 4th tone it becomes 2nd; it becomes second tone before a fourth tone; rising, before a fourth tone**5.4 Practice** — *answering either way***Answer:** a word you keep or turn**Also accepted:** the word, kept or negated; you echo it or negate it; one word and two things to do with it

Sources for this starter edition

Character shapes, components, and stroke order follow this project's curated character inventory, whose stroke orders are marked authoritative because Chinese stroke order is a standardised taught system rather than a convention. Codepoint and glyph references are to the Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart.

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Look up an English meaning, a dedicated language topic, or a chapter topic. Each linked reference opens the chapter where the material is introduced; the focus labels name only explicitly typed lesson sections.

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four 四 (sì)

explicit focus: pronunciation, usage and culture; Chapter 3, p. 21

G

good, well 好 (hǎo)

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1

H

hello (literally “you good”) 你好 (nǐ hǎo)

explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 1, p. 1

I

is not — and a pitch that moves to get out of the way 不是 (bú shì)

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mā má mǎ mà — one syllable, four words

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亻 — the same person, standing sideways

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口 — the box, on its own

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